The New Algorhythm

HAVING RELEASED A SINGLE ON AN AI-POWERED MUSIC LABEL, **ANKUR TEWARI** IS DELIGHTING IN NEW AUDIENCES



What do you get when you mix an eminent singer-songwriter, known for his organic approach to music, and a label that is all about the zeroes and ones of artificial intelligence? The answer is 'Shehzaada Shehzaadi', a lovely ditty by Ankur Tewari, made in collaboration with AI-powered music label Snafu.

Launched in 2018, the label recently raised $6 million (Rs 44.5 crore) in funding, with investors like ABBA's Agnetha Fältskog and Grammy-nominated songwriter Savan Harish Kotecha. Snafu works like this: an AI-powered algorithm analyses data from over 150,000 songs per week and identifies which artists need amplification, based on listener engagement and the music itself. "When my manager first told me that the label was interested in working with me, I was quite apprehensive," says Tewari, adding that he likes to meet and engage with people he is going to work with. "As long as they are not bots," he says with a laugh. "I had gone in with the impression that they wouldn't understand what I was about, but to my surprise, they were quite in tune with what I was saying."

Now, after understanding how the label is using AI to break into new markets, Tewari appreciates its merits. "I can see that this song is breaking new ground and new markets. My music is being played in places where it was not played before, like Sweden, Austria and Germany, places where I don't have my core fan base," he says.

The song itself was written quite recently by Tewari. "I thought it was time I record a song and put something new out there, so I decided to go through my catalogue of songs I had not recorded yet. While doing that, somehow this song happened. Everything fell into place in a few hours... the words, the music," he says. Tewari muses that he hadn't written a love song in a while, and at this point, everyone could do with more love.

At the moment, Tewari is enjoying all the love and adoration his single is getting. He recently performed live for the first time and was pleased to see the crowd singing along.

He is also currently working on Shakun Batra's upcoming film *Gahraiyaan*, starring Deepika Padukone, Siddhant Chaturvedi and Ananya Panday, as a music supervisor, as well as on Zoya Akhtar's *The Archies* for Netflix. "I even have a new album on the horizon, aimed at a February release," he adds. ■

–Vijayeta Basu

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